

HOW TO HOLD THE GUITAR

- Rest the body on the leg matching your dominant hand (right-handed = right leg)
- Hug the body of the guitar against you
- Dominant arm crosses the front near the bridge: this is your strumming hand
- Other hand wraps around the neck: this is your fretting hand
- Press with the **tip** of each finger, just behind the fret bar: not on top of it
- Thumb presses the back of the neck

FRETS + FINGER NUMBERS

A **fret** is the space between two metal bars. Moving up one fret raises the pitch by one half step. Open string (no finger pressed) = fret 0.

FRETTING HAND FINGER NUMBERS

T = Thumb

1 = Index finger

2 = Middle finger

3 = Ring finger

4 = Pinky



Thumb sits on the back of the neck. Numbers refer to fretting hand fingers only.

PARTS OF THE GUITAR

Headstock

strings anchor here, holds tuners

Tuning pegs

adjust pitch

Nut

zero fret, top of neck, holds strings

Neck

long part you hold

Fretboard

where fingers press

Fret bars

metal fret dividers

Body

largest part of the guitar

Sound hole

provides acoustic resonance

Bridge

strings anchor here

Saddle

sits on bridge, holds strings

Strap pegs

attach your strap

Pickups

electric guitars only

STRING NAMES

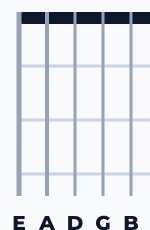
Six strings, thickest to thinnest:

#	Name/Note	Position
6 (thickest)	E	closest to you
5	A	
4	D	
3	G	
2	B	
1 (thinnest)	e	closest to floor

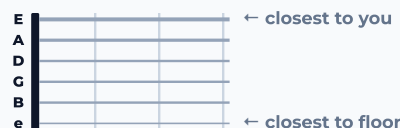
Memory Phrase:

Eddie Ate Dynamite, Good Bye Eddie

CHORD DIAGRAM VIEW



LOOKING DOWN AT YOUR GUITAR



TUNING YOUR GUITAR

Make sure you tune your guitar before getting started.

Standard tuning: E A D G B e, thickest to thinnest.

How to use a clip-on tuner: Clip it to the headstock. Pluck one string at a time and let it ring. Turn the tuning peg slowly while watching the display.

Reading the tuner: Flat means the pitch is too low. Tighten the string (turn the peg to increase tension) to raise it. Sharp means the pitch is too high. Loosen the string to lower it. When the needle centers and the display turns green, you are in tune.

Pro tip: Always tune up to a note rather than down to it. If you overshoot and go too sharp, drop below the note and tune back up. This keeps the string under consistent tension and holds tuning longer.

THE MUSICAL ALPHABET

Only 7 letters, then it repeats. Same note, higher pitch = an **octave**.

(A) W (B) H (C) W (D) W (E) H (F) W (G) W (A) ...

W = Whole step (2 frets) **H = Half step (1 fret)**

Half steps only: B to C and E to F. Everything else is a whole step.

Memory Phrase: Birthday Cake: Everyone's Favorite.

READING TAB

Tab shows you *where* to play on the guitar. Each line = a string. Numbers = fret. 0 = open string.

Note: Strings are shown highest pitch to lowest. e (thinnest) is on top, E (thickest) is on the bottom.

```
e | -----0--0--0--2--4--4--2--0---2--4---0--- |
B | --0----- |
G | ----- |
D | ----- |
A | ----- |
E | ----- |
```

Itsy Bitsy Spider (opening phrase). Full tab at steadystepsmusic.com/tab

How to play it:

Use whatever left hand finger feels most comfortable. Pick one note at a time with your right hand thumb.

Play slowly and sing the words in your head as you go.

MELODY, HARMONY, AND RHYTHM

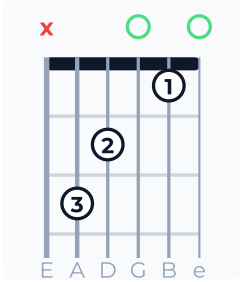
Melody: Notes played one at a time, in sequence. When you hum a song, you are singing the melody.
(play the melody in the tab above)

Harmony: Notes played together at the same time. A chord is harmony.
(see chords section below)

Rhythm: The timing and pattern of when notes are played. A single note played with great rhythm can be more musical than ten notes played with no rhythm.
(tap your foot to the beat)

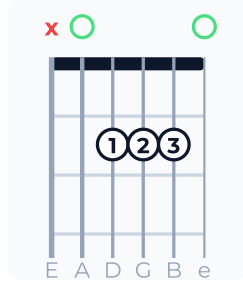
MAJOR CHORDS

C Major



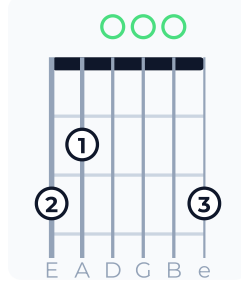
1: fret 1, B
2: fret 2, D
3: fret 3, A
Skip E

A Major



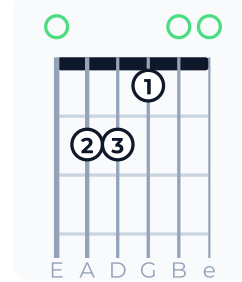
1: fret 2, D
2: fret 2, G
3: fret 2, B
Skip E

G Major



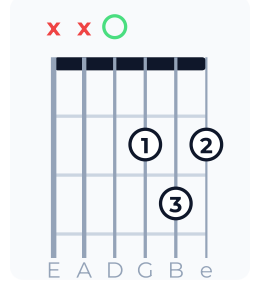
1: fret 2, A
2: fret 3, E
3: fret 3, e
Strum all 6

E Major



1: fret 1, G
2: fret 2, A
3: fret 2, D
Strum all 6

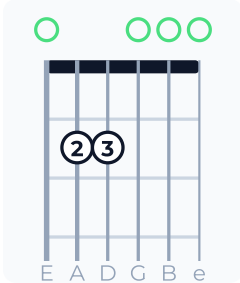
D Major



1: fret 2, G
2: fret 2, e
3: fret 3, B
Skip E and A

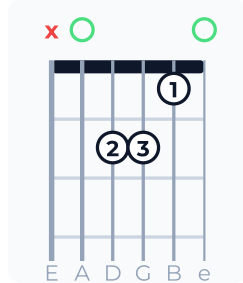
MINOR CHORDS

E Minor



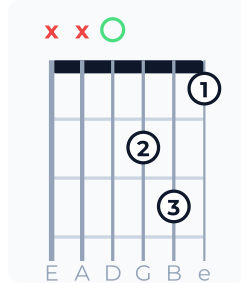
2: fret 2, A
3: fret 2, D
Strum all 6

A Minor



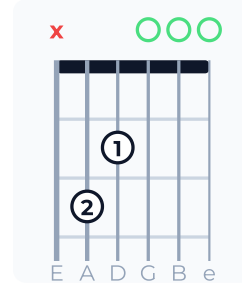
1: fret 1, B
2: fret 2, D
3: fret 2, G
Skip E

D Minor



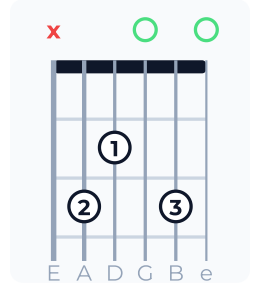
1: fret 1, e
2: fret 2, G
3: fret 3, B
Skip E and A

C Maj 7



1: fret 2, D
2: fret 3, A
G, B, e open
Skip low E

C Add 9



1: fret 2, D
2: fret 3, A
3: fret 3, B
G, e open
Skip low E

BONUS CHORDS

Steady Steps Music

Free beginner resource. Share it with anyone learning guitar.

Ready to go further?

Book a free intro lesson
steadystepsmusic.com